

Malicious PDF Awareness Training

Purpose: This document is for education and defense only. It explains how malicious PDFs try to deceive users, what red flags to look for, and how to stay safe. No exploits or harmful content are included.

1) What Is a Malicious PDF?

A malicious PDF is a document designed to trick users into performing unsafe actions or exploiting software vulnerabilities. Attackers often rely on social engineering rather than technical sophistication.

Common social engineering themes include:

- Urgent messages ("Action required", "Invoice overdue")
- Authority impersonation (bank, HR, government)
- Curiosity or rewards ("View exam results", "Salary update")

2) Typical Red Flags

- Unexpected attachments from unknown senders
- Requests to enable macros or click embedded links
- Poor grammar or mismatched sender domains
- File names mimicking trusted documents

3) How Attacks Are Prevented (High-Level)

Organizations reduce risk using layered defenses such as email filtering, sandboxing, up-to-date PDF readers, and user training. Individuals should keep software updated and verify senders before opening attachments.

4) Safe Handling Checklist

- Verify the sender independently
- Hover over links to inspect destinations
- Do not enable macros or scripts in PDFs
- Use antivirus and open files in a sandbox when possible

5) Conclusion

Awareness is the strongest defense. Understanding social engineering tactics helps users identify and avoid malicious documents.